SOFTBALL · GIRLS AND WOMEN · GRADES 9 TO 12 · SPORT PLAYBOOK

WOMEN'S SOFTBALL: THE WHOLE ROAD TO COLLEGE

What to do, when to do it, who pays, and what a coach is and is not allowed to tell you. Built from the 2026-27 NCAA rule text, the printed softball recruiting calendar with its dead periods and shutdowns, the NAIA and junior college rule books, and the camp and club prices a family actually sees.

VERSION
2026-27 · sample player: class of 2029

RULES CHECKED
11 November 2026, against the NCAA rule text, the printed 2026-27 softball recruiting calendar, the NAIA and junior college rule books and the service pages quoted

LEVELS COVERED
D1 · D2 · D3 · NAIA · junior college

> About 338,000 girls play high school softball and 21,916 play it in the NCAA, which is 6.5 percent. Softball is a spring sport, and its June recruiting dates move with the Women's College World Series, so the year a family is planning on is not always the year printed. This book shows which dates are printed, which are worked out from the rule, and which no association publishes at all.

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This is education. It is not legal advice or school advice. It promises no result, no playing time, no acceptance, and no money. The NCAA Eligibility Center makes the final call on school rules, and each school decides its own aid. Dates marked HARD are printed in the 2026-27 softball calendar. Dates marked PROJECTED are worked out from the rule text, not printed by the NCAA yet. Chapter 3 lists them.

1. READ THIS FIRST

Read Chapter 2 before you spend any money. Then put the plan in Chapter 3 on one page and cross items off. The rest is for looking things up: what the rules allow, what to send, what the paper means, and what it costs.

THE MAIN IDEA

Softball does not run on the general recruiting dates. Division I softball has its own contact dates, and they are later than the general rule. It also has its own calendar, and the June part of that calendar moves every year. A family that knows the real dates does not waste a call, a camp fee or a trip.

This book is for the parent of a girl in the class of 2029. She is in 10th grade in 2026-27. Every rule here was read in the rule books on 11 November 2026. Each one carries its bylaw number or its document, so you can check it. Chapter 11 lists every document and its web address.

WHAT MAKES SOFTBALL DIFFERENT

- **Its own start date.** A Division I softball coach may not call your daughter, send her recruiting email or meet her before 1 p.m. Central time on 1 September of junior year. For her, that day is 1 September 2027. One recruiting site this book read prints 15 June. That is the general rule for other sports. It is not the softball rule.
- **A calendar that moves.** The NCAA prints one softball calendar a year. The June dates on it are set from the Women's College World Series. When that event moves, the dates move.
- **A roster number, not a scholarship number.** At a Division I school under the House settlement, the limit is now 25 players on the team. The old limit was 12 scholarships. Chapter 2 covers the 25-player limit, and why it is not 25 scholarships.

Proof: Division I Manual 2026-27, Bylaws 13.1.3.1.4, 13.4.1.4, 13.1.1.1.2 and 17.2, and the printed 2026-27 Division I softball recruiting calendar, updated 30 July 2026. Read 11 November 2026.

THREE RULES THAT SURPRISE FAMILIES

- **The coach may not take her call.** Before 1 September of junior year, a Division I softball coach may not pick up when she or a parent calls. Silence in 9th or 10th grade is the rule. It is not a no. This is Bylaw 13.1.3.2.8.
- **The first day a coach may call is a day the coach may not meet her.** On the printed 2026-27 calendar, 28 August to 3 September is a dead period. A dead period means no meeting in person and no visits. So on 1 September the phone opens and the door stays shut. This is our reading of the rule and the calendar side by side.
- **There is no National Letter of Intent now.** Division I ended it on 9 October 2024, and Division II followed that month. The paper is now a written offer of athletics aid. Chapter 7 covers it.

HOW THIS BOOK MARKS A DATE OR A NUMBER

MARK	WHAT IT MEANS
HARD	Printed by the body that owns the rule. Every date on the 2026-27 softball calendar is HARD.
PROJECTED	A date this book worked out from rule text. The NCAA has not printed it yet. Her junior and senior year dates are all like this, because those calendars are not out.
SERVICE	A price or a number from a company's own page. It is not a rule, and it can change.

WORDS THIS BOOK USES

WORD	WHAT IT MEANS HERE
CONTACT PERIOD	Coaches may meet players in person away from campus. They may also watch them play.
EVALUATION PERIOD	Coaches may watch away from campus. They may not meet her in person away from campus. To evaluate just means to watch and judge.
QUIET PERIOD	Coaches may meet a player in person only on the college's own campus.
DEAD PERIOD	No meeting in person and no watching, on campus or off. No visits of either kind.
RECRUITING SHUTDOWN	No recruiting of any form. No calls made or taken, no mail, no visits, no watching.
SCHOLASTIC	Her high school team: its games and its practices.
NONSCHOLASTIC	Softball that is not her school team. For most girls that means travel ball with a club.
OFFICIAL VISIT	A campus visit the college pays for.
UNOFFICIAL VISIT	A campus visit the family pays for.
ROSTER LIMIT	A cap on people, not money. It is 25 in Division I softball at a settlement school.
EQUIVALENCY	A cap on money that a coach may cut into pieces. Division II softball has 7.2. The NAIA has 10.
SETTLEMENT SCHOOL	A Division I school in one of the five defendant conferences, or one that opted in to the House settlement. That court deal changed the money rules on 1 July 2025. A defendant conference is one of the five named in that case.
CORE COURSE	A high school class the NCAA approves. She needs 16 of them.
JUNIOR COLLEGE	A two-year college. This book covers the ones in the NJCAA.
LETTER OF INTENT	The paper a player signs to commit to one junior college for a school year. Division I and II ended their own letter in October 2024.
REQUEST LIST	A college's own list of the players it is recruiting. She must be on it before a paid Division I visit. It is not an offer.
12U, 14U, 16U, 18U	Age groups in travel ball. 14U means players 14 and under.

The five period meanings are printed on the 2026-27 softball calendar itself. Read 11 November 2026.

2. HOW MANY PLAYERS A TEAM CAN TAKE

Start with the size of the team. A coach adds players as places open. This chapter gives the limit at each level, the real squad sizes, and the odds. Each number names the page it came from.

THE LIMIT AT EACH LEVEL

LEVEL	THE LIMIT	WHERE IT IS WRITTEN
DIVISION I, SETTLEMENT SCHOOL	A roster limit of 25 players. No limit on the number of scholarships. Aid may be any size, full or partial. No school has to give a full one.	Division I Manual 2026-27, Bylaw 17.2. College Sports Commission roster limits page. NCAA settlement question-and-answer, updated 29 May 2026, items B2 and B3. In force since 1 July 2025.
DIVISION I, OTHER SCHOOLS	The old aid limit: 12 scholarships for the whole team. The coach may split them among players.	The same question-and-answer, item B2. It sends these schools to the 2024-25 Division I Manual.
DIVISION II	7.2 scholarships' worth of money for the team. It is an equivalency, so coaches split it.	Division II Manual 2026-27, Bylaw 15.4.2.1.2, table revised 16 January 2026.
DIVISION III	No athletics aid at all. Aid is for grades or need. The NCAA guide says 80% of athletes get aid that is not for sports.	Division III Manual 2026-27, Bylaw 15.01.3. Guide for the College-Bound Student-Athlete 2026-27.
NAIA	10 full grants' worth of money for the team. No roster limit.	NAIA Official Handbook 2026-2027, financial aid policy, items D and H.
JUNIOR COLLEGE (NJCAA)	At most 24 players signed to a letter of intent. That is the paper a player signs to commit to one junior college for a school year. A signed player counts as one of the 24, however small her aid.	NJCAA Sports Procedures Chart for 2026-27. It says it is tentative as of 16 December 2025. The chart is reissued during the year, so check the association's own page for the newest file.

All six rows were read on 11 November 2026.

THE 25-PLAYER LIMIT, AND WHY IT IS NOT 25 SCHOLARSHIPS

One recruiting site says Division I softball teams are allowed "up to 25 scholarships per year." The rule does not say that. The 25 is a cap on people. The cap on scholarships was taken away at settlement schools. The College Sports Commission prints the softball row of its table like this:

> "old scholarship limit 12, new roster limit 25, potential increase in scholarships 13."

The key word is potential. A school may fund 25 players. It may fund far fewer.

Which schools are settlement schools? Every school in the five defendant conferences is one. Any other Division I school may opt in. This book found no public list of the schools that did. So ask each school in writing: "Are you under the 25-player roster limit, or the old 12 scholarships?"

HOW THE 25-PLAYER LIMIT WORKS

- The school turns in its roster by the day before its first game that counts toward the championship, or by 1 December. The earlier date wins.
- After that, only listed players may take part in team activities.
- Anyone who gets an athletics scholarship or settlement payments must be on the list.

Proof: College Sports Commission roster limits page. Read 11 November 2026.

REAL SQUAD SIZES, AND THE SQUAD ARITHMETIC

LEVEL	PLAYERS	TEAMS	AVERAGE SQUAD	DIVIDED BY FOUR
DIVISION I	6,956	301	23.1	about 5.8
DIVISION II	6,525	283	23.1	about 5.8
DIVISION III	8,435	399	21.1	about 5.3
ALL THREE	21,916	983	22.3	not worked out

Players, teams and averages: NCAA Sports Sponsorship and Participation Rates Report, the 2024-25 table on PDF page 94. Read 11 November 2026. A player here is anyone on the squad list at any point in the year. The last column is this book's arithmetic. It is not a published number.

Now the part nobody prints. Take the average squad and divide it by four class years. A team can add about five or six new players a year. That is a ceiling, and it is arithmetic. It assumes four equal classes and no transfers. Each transfer a coach takes is one fewer place for a high school player. So the real number for high school girls is lower. No association publishes how many players a team recruits each year. The NCAA, NAIA and NJCAA pages this book read were all checked for it.

HOW MANY TEAMS THERE ARE

WHICH COUNT	DIVISION I	DIVISION II	DIVISION III	TOTAL
2026-27, projected by the NCAA, data final 29 July 2026	308	274	396	978
2024-25, counted after the season	301	283	399	983
The year before, same report	297	282	403	982

First row: NCAA membership and sport sponsorship page. Other rows: the participation report, PDF pages 94 and 92. Read 11 November 2026. Three counts are in use because they are three different years.

Below the NCAA the counts are weaker. This book found no official softball total for either level.

LEVEL	TEAMS	WHERE THE COUNT CAME FROM
NAIA	194, or 197.	194 is a count of the NAIA's official 2025-26 standings page on 11 November 2026. Two of the 194 showed no games played. 197 is one recruiting company's number.
JUNIOR COLLEGE	364, not settled. See Chapter 5.	One recruiting company's number. It covers all junior colleges, not only the NJCAA.

SERVICE The 197 and the 364 come from one company's table, which shows no date. Read 11 November 2026.

THE ODDS, FROM THE NCAA'S OWN TABLE

The NCAA's table was last updated in March 2026. It says 338,315 girls play high school softball. It says 21,916 play NCAA softball. That is 6.5 percent. By level it is 2.1 percent to Division I, 1.9 percent to Division II and 2.5 percent to Division III.

The NCAA prints its method too. It divides its own players by the high school count. The high school count is the 2024-25 High School Athletics Participation Survey. It is run by NFHS, the National Federation of State High School Associations. Club teams are not included. The NCAA count is from its own 2024-25 participation report. Only NCAA schools are counted. So a girl who plays NAIA or junior college softball is not in the 6.5 percent.

One recruiting company prints other odds: 7.8 percent to any college and 1.6 percent to Division I. It gives no year. Its Division I figure does not match the NCAA's 2.1 percent. SERVICE

Proof: NCAA Research, estimated probability of competing beyond high school, figures and method. Read 11 November 2026.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR DAUGHTER

Ask each coach three things. How many players are on the roster now? How many leave before fall 2029? How many of the open places go to transfers? The answers tell you more than any national number in this chapter.

3. THE PLAN BY DATE, CLASS OF 2029

She is in 10th grade in 2026-27. The NCAA has printed one softball calendar so far that covers her: 2026-27. Her junior year is 2027-28 and her senior year is 2028-29. Neither of those calendars is published yet. So this chapter has two main tables. The first is the printed calendar, period by period. The second is her own road, worked out from the rule text.

THE PRINTED CALENDAR: DIVISION I SOFTBALL, 2026-27

WHEN	THE PERIOD, AS THE CALENDAR PRINTS IT	WHAT IT MEANS FOR HER
1-9 AUG 2026 HARD	Contact period.	Coaches could meet players off campus and watch them. A 10th grader could be watched. She could not be met.
10 AUG-22 NOV 2026 HARD	Evaluation period "for scholastic practice and competition activities only."	Coaches may watch high school softball. They may not meet her in person off campus.
28 AUG-3 SEP 2026 HARD	Dead period. It sits inside the evaluation period.	No meeting in person. No watching. No visits of either kind. Note that 1 September falls inside these dates.
17-18 OCT 2026 **24-25 OCT 2026** **31 OCT-1 NOV 2026** **7-8 NOV 2026** **14-15 NOV 2026** **21-22 NOV 2026** HARD	Evaluation period "for scholastic and nonscholastic practice or competition activities."	Six fall weekends. On these days coaches may also watch travel ball.
9-12 NOV 2026 HARD	Dead period. It also sits inside the evaluation period.	It wraps the first signing date, 11 November 2026. No meeting, no watching, no visits.
23 NOV 2026-2 JAN 2027 HARD	Quiet period.	Coaches may meet older players only on the college's campus. A 10th grader may not be met at all.
25-29 NOV 2026 HARD	Recruiting shutdown. It sits inside the quiet period.	Nothing at all. No calls made or taken, no mail, no visits, no watching.
9-12 DEC 2026 HARD	Dead period. It sits inside the quiet period.	No meeting in person, no watching, no visits.
22-26 DEC 2026 HARD	Recruiting shutdown.	Nothing at all, as above.
31 DEC 2026-2 JAN 2027 HARD	Recruiting shutdown.	Nothing at all, as above. The quiet period ends with it.
3 JAN-31 MAY 2027 HARD	Evaluation period "for scholastic practice and competition activities only."	High school softball only. Coaches may watch her school team. They may not meet her off campus.

Proof: 2026-27 NCAA Recruiting Calendar, Division I Softball, updated 30 July 2026. The Division I Manual no longer prints sport calendars. Bylaw 13.17, revised 7 October 2026, sends readers to the NCAA site. Read 11 November 2026.

WHEN	THE PERIOD, AS THE CALENDAR PRINTS IT	WHAT IT MEANS FOR HER
1-11 JUN 2027* HARD	Dead period. The asterisk is the calendar's own.	No meeting, no watching, no visits, until the college season is over.
12 JUN*-31 JUL 2027 HARD	Contact period. The asterisk is the calendar's own.	The summer window. Coaches may watch any softball, travel ball included. She is still before 1 September of junior year, so she can be watched but not met.
DATES NOT PRINTED HARD	One more evaluation period: "During high school regional and state championship competition that does not occur during a dead period."	The rule is printed. The dates are not. They come from your state association.

Proof: 2026-27 NCAA Recruiting Calendar, Division I Softball, updated 30 July 2026. The Division I Manual no longer prints sport calendars. Bylaw 13.17, revised 7 October 2026, sends readers to the NCAA site. Read 11 November 2026.

THE CALENDAR'S OWN ASTERISK

The two June dates carry an asterisk on the printed page. WCWS in it is short for the Women's College World Series. So the June dates are set from that event's schedule. They move every year. The asterisk reads: "Dates are based on the Women's College World Series. If the WCWS dates are delayed, the dead period continues through the day of the final championship game. If the WCWS ends after two games, the dead period concludes on the day of the final game and the contact period begins the next day."

THE DAY THE PHONE OPENS, THE DOOR IS STILL SHUT

Coaches may first call at 1 p.m. Central time on 1 September of junior year. On the printed 2026-27 calendar, 28 August to 3 September is a dead period. So 1 September sits inside a dead period. The first day a softball coach may talk to a girl is a day the coach still may not meet her. No meeting in person. No visit, paid or unpaid. Calls and email are open. This is this book's reading of the rule and the calendar side by side. The NCAA does not print it as one line.

For your daughter the day is 1 September 2027. The 2027-28 calendar is not printed. So nobody can say yet where that dead period will fall. If it sits in the same week again, plan the first visit for after it ends.

TWO MORE PRINTED DATES FOR 2026-27

WHEN	WHAT IS PRINTED	WHERE
9 NOV, 7 A.M., TO 11 NOV, 7 A.M., 2026 HARD	Division II dead period for softball's group, "all other sports." A Division II coach may still call and write in a dead period. Meeting, watching and visits stop.	2026-27 Division II recruiting calendar, updated 30 July 2026. Division II Manual, Bylaw 13.02.10.
11 NOV 2026 HARD	First signing date for softball's group, "All Other Division I and II Sports." The last date is set by each school's own policy.	NCAA signing dates sheet for 2026-27. Division I Manual, Figure 13-2.

Read 11 November 2026. The Division II dead period starts at 7 a.m. on 9 November 2026. The other dead periods on the Division II page sit under a football heading, and the manual lists them as football's. The month grid colors them too, so the grid alone can mislead. Division III has no recruiting calendar. The NAIA says it has none. The junior college bylaws print none.

HER OWN DATES, WORKED OUT FROM THE RULES

WHEN	WHAT OPENS, AND THE RULE IT COMES FROM	WHAT YOUR FAMILY DOES
PROJECTED 1 JUN 2027	A junior college may pay for a visit. The rule says "starting on June 1 prior to their junior year in high school." NJCAA Bylaws 2026-27, Article VI, Section 4.B.1.	Put two junior colleges on her list now. Chapter 4 shows what the college may pay for.
PROJECTED 15 JUN 2027	A Division II coach may meet her in person, and a Division II school may pay for a visit. The rule says not before "June 15 immediately preceding" junior year. Division II Manual, Bylaws 13.1.1.1 and 13.3.1.1.	Division II coaches may call and write before this date. Answer them. Ask for a visit after it.
PROJECTED 1 SEP 2027 1 P.M. CENTRAL	Division I softball opens. A coach may call her, take her call, send email and mail, meet her off campus, talk recruiting at a camp, and host a visit. Seven bylaws carry this one date: 13.1.3.1.4, 13.1.3.2.8, 13.4.1.4, 13.1.1.1.2, 13.12.1.5.4, 13.6.2.1.4 and 13.7.1.4.	Send the email in Chapter 6 that week. Do not book a visit for that week yet. This year the same week is a dead period.
PROJECTED 1 JAN 2028	A Division III school may pay for a visit. The rule says not "earlier than January 1" of junior year. Division III Manual, Bylaw 13.6.1.1.	Division III coaches may write at any time. Ask for a winter visit.
PROJECTED JUN 2028	The June dead period, then the summer contact period. The NCAA has printed the 2028 Women's College World Series. It starts 1 June 2028. The final series is 7, 8 and, if needed, 9 June. The recruiting calendar for that June is not printed yet. The sources are the asterisk on the 2026-27 calendar and the NCAA's future championship dates page.	Do not copy 1 to 11 June and 12 June from this year. Read the 2027-28 calendar when it comes out.
PROJECTED 1 AUG 2028	A school may hand her a written offer about payments for her name, image and likeness, or a share of school revenue. She may not sign it until the signing date. The rule says "on or after August 1" of senior year. NCAA settlement question-and-answer, updated 29 May 2026, item B11.	Read it. Ask what it covers and for how long. Do not sign early.
PROJECTED FALL 2028	Her seventh semester starts. Before it does she needs 10 of her 16 core courses done. Seven of the 10 must be in English, math and science. Guide for the College-Bound Student-Athlete 2026-27, page 14.	Count her approved classes with the counselor in spring 2028, not in the fall.

WHEN	WHAT OPENS, AND THE RULE IT COMES FROM	WHAT YOUR FAMILY DOES
PROJECTED 1 NOV 2028	Junior college softball signing date. The chart prints "Nov 1." She must have finished junior year to sign. NJCAA 2026-2027 Sports Procedures Chart and Bylaws, Article VI.	A junior college letter lasts one school year. Read Chapter 7 before she signs one.
PROJECTED WED 8 NOV 2028	First day to sign a written offer of athletics aid in Division I and II. The rule is the second Wednesday in November, at 7 a.m. in Division I. This year the NCAA printed it as 11 November 2026. It has printed no 2028-29 date. Division I Manual, Bylaw 13.02.13.1(f). Division II Manual, Bylaw 13.02.10.1(c).	Ask for the amount in writing in September 2028. Expect a dead period that week. Its 2028 dates are not printed.

All rules read 11 November 2026. The dates are this book's arithmetic from those rules.

WHY HER DATES SAY PROJECTED

A class-of-2029 family is planning against dates that do not exist yet. The 2027-28 and 2028-29 softball calendars are not published. On 11 November 2026 the NCAA recruiting page linked only 2026-27 files. That is why the PROJECTED tag is on her dates. A rule can also change before she gets there. Check each date again when the new calendar is printed.

4. WHAT A COACH MAY AND MAY NOT DO

Each level has its own rules. Division I softball is the strict one, and it has its own dates. Read the first table slowly. It is the one a recruiting site can get wrong.

DIVISION I SOFTBALL HAS ITS OWN CLOCK

One time and date runs through the Division I softball rules: 1 p.m. Central time on 1 September of junior year. Junior year means the school year that starts in the fall of 11th grade. For the class of 2029 that day is 1 September 2027. The softball lines in the rule book carry the note "Adopted: 6/24/26," which is 24 June 2026.

WHAT	THE SOFTBALL RULE	BYLAW
COACH CALLS HER	Not before 1 p.m. Central on 1 September of junior year. After that the school may call as it sees fit.	13.1.3.1.4
SHE CALLS THE COACH	Before that same time, the staff may not take a call from her or from her family.	13.1.3.2.8
EMAIL AND MAIL	Nothing about the program by mail, by email or by any other electronic message before that same time. The school may answer her own letter or email if the answer says nothing about the athletics program. Camp information may be sent at any time. The rule's own term is "electronic correspondence."	13.4.1.4, 13.4.1.13, 13.4.1.14(b)
MEETING OFF CAMPUS	No in-person contact away from campus, with her or her family, before that same time.	13.1.1.1.2
TALK AT A CAMP	No recruiting conversation at a college camp or clinic before that same time. This holds even at a camp for younger girls.	13.12.1.5.4
PAID VISIT	No expense-paid visit before that same time.	13.6.2.1.4
UNPAID VISIT	No unofficial visit that involves the athletics staff, a team tour or free tickets before that same time.	13.7.1.4

Proof: Division I Manual 2026-27. Read 11 November 2026.

WHY "JUNE 15" IS WRONG FOR SOFTBALL

One softball recruiting site, on a page marked "Updated August 2026," prints this:

> "D1 and D2: Coaches cannot call, text, or email you until June 15 after your sophomore year. You can contact them any time."

June 15 is real. It is the general Division I rule, for sports that have no rule of their own. Softball has its own, and it is later. The table shows both, so you can see the gap.

WHAT	GENERAL DIVISION I RULE	SOFTBALL RULE	FOR THE CLASS OF 2029
EMAIL AND MAIL	15 June at the end of sophomore year. Bylaw 13.4.1.	1 September of junior year, 1 p.m. Central. Bylaw 13.4.1.4.	15 June 2027 against 1 September 2027.
MEETING OFF CAMPUS	1 August at the start of junior year. Bylaw 13.1.1.1.	1 September of junior year, 1 p.m. Central. Bylaw 13.1.1.1.2.	1 August 2027 against 1 September 2027.

The site is wrong about Division II as well. Division II coaches may call and write at any time. And "contact them any time" misses a rule. Before 1 September of junior year, a Division I softball coach may not take her call.

HOW MANY TIMES A DIVISION I COACH MAY SEE HER

- Each school gets seven recruiting chances per player per year. A meeting counts as one. A trip to watch her counts as one. The rule's word is "opportunities."
- From 1 September of junior year, the seven may hold no more than three off-campus meetings a year. Meeting her family counts too.
- A meeting during an official or unofficial visit does not count.
- Trips to watch her from 1 June through 31 August do not count against the seven. Trips from 1 September through 31 May do, unless a meeting happens the same day.
- Any number of meetings in one day counts as one.
- A school may send only four off-campus recruiters out on any one day.

Proof: Division I Manual 2026-27, Bylaws 13.1.5.9, 13.1.5.11, 13.1.5.12, 11.7.3.3 and 11.7.6.3. Read 11 November 2026.

THE OTHER FOUR LEVELS

LEVEL	CALLS, EMAIL, MAIL	MEETING IN PERSON	RULE
DIVISION II	At any time. There is no softball rule. Softball follows the all-sports rule.	Not before 15 June just before junior year. After that, no limits. At a game she must be done for the day and released first.	Division II Manual, Bylaws 13.1.3.1 and 13.1.1.1. Division II coaches' recruiting guide, updated 30 July 2026.
DIVISION III	At any time. The rule names calls, email, texts and private social media messages.	Off campus, not until she has finished sophomore year. Coaches may watch her as often as they like.	Division III Manual, Bylaws 13.02.10, 13.4.1.1, 13.1.1.1 and 13.1.4.
NAIA	All year. No limit on how often or how.	No calendar. A school may hold a tryout for her. See the note below on its length.	NAIA recruiting page. NAIA Official Handbook 2026-2027, Article II, Section C.
JUNIOR COLLEGE	The bylaws set no start date and no limit for high school players.	Staff may visit her at any place to recruit. They may not spend money on her or her family.	NJCAA Bylaws 2026-27, Article VI, Sections 4.C and 4.D.

Read 11 November 2026. NAIA tryouts have two official wordings. The handbook allows two days "for a specific student per member institution" and no more. Two NAIA web pages, dated 11 May 2026, allow two days "throughout your entire athletic career" and no more. The two do not agree. Ask the school which one it follows.

VISITS: HOW LONG, AND WHO IS PAID FOR

LEVEL	FIRST PAID VISIT	HOW LONG	WHO THE COLLEGE MAY PAY FOR
DIVISION I	1 September of junior year, 1 p.m. Central. One paid visit per school before 15 October after high school.	No more than two nights of lodging in a row.	Her travel. The round trip for up to two family members. Lodging and meals for her and up to four family members, at most three meals a day. Up to $60 a person for entertainment. Up to five free tickets to a home game.
DIVISION II	15 June just before junior year. One paid visit per school.	No more than 48 hours.	Her round trip. Her lodging. Meals for her and for the family or others with her. Lodging for them too. Free tickets to a campus game.
DIVISION III	1 January of junior year. One paid visit per school.	No more than 48 hours.	Lodging and meals as regular students get them, within 30 miles of campus. Free tickets to a home game for her and those with her.
NAIA	No date and no count in the handbook.	No limit printed.	Travel, meals and lodging only if the school does the same for other students with special talents.
JUNIOR COLLEGE	1 June before junior year. One paid visit per college per recruiting year.	No more than 48 hours.	Her and two guests: travel, meals and lodging by the college's own policy. Campus and the local town only. No tickets beyond what the public gets.

Proof: Division I Manual, Bylaws 13.6.2.1.4, 13.6.2.2, 13.6.4, 13.5.2.1, 13.5.2.6, 13.6.6, 13.6.7.2, 13.6.7.4 and 13.6.7.7. Division II Manual, Bylaws 13.3.1.1, 13.3.1.2, 13.3.3, 13.3.4.1, 13.3.5, 13.3.6.2, 13.3.7 and 13.3.8. Division III Manual, Bylaws 13.6.1.1, 13.6.1.1.1, 13.6.2, 13.6.4, 13.6.5.2 and 13.6.6. NAIA Official Handbook 2026-2027, Article II, Section C, Item 3. NJCAA Bylaws, Article VI, Section 4.B.1. Read 11 November 2026.

BEFORE A DIVISION I PAID VISIT

Three things must be done first. This is Bylaw 13.6.3.

1. She sends the school a transcript.
2. She is registered with the NCAA Eligibility Center.
3. She is on the school's request list.

The rule book calls it the institutional request list. It is the school's own list of the players it is recruiting. Ask the coach to add her. Being on the list is not an offer, and it does not commit her to that school.

FOUR MORE RULES ABOUT VISITS

- **Unpaid visits in Division I** have no limit on number. The family pays. The school may give up to three free tickets to a home game, and none in a dead period. Bylaws 13.7.2 and 13.7.3.1.
- **"The family pays for everything" is not quite true.** On an unpaid visit a Division II school may pay the real cost of meals. A Division III school may give one meal in its dining hall. Division II Bylaw 13.4.2.1.2 and Division III Bylaw 13.7.2.1.1.
- **Junior college unpaid visits** come with no expense or benefit. She may take up to two that include playing with the team. NJCAA Bylaws, Article VI, Section 4.B.2.
- **After she signs** a written offer of athletics aid, other schools that give athletics aid must stop recruiting her. NCAA news release, 9 October 2024.

5. CLUB, CAMPS, AND WHERE SHE IS SEEN

A Division I coach may not watch just any game on just any day. The calendar says which kind of softball may be watched, and when. Learn that first. Then pick the events.

TWO KINDS OF SOFTBALL, TWO SETS OF DAYS

The calendar uses two words. Scholastic means her high school team. Nonscholastic means the rest, which for most girls is travel ball. Here is what the printed 2026-27 calendar lets a Division I coach do.

WHEN	KIND OF PERIOD	WHAT A DIVISION I COACH MAY WATCH
1-9 AUG 2026	Contact period	High school softball and travel ball.
10 AUG-22 NOV 2026	Evaluation period	High school softball only, but see the next row.
SIX FALL WEEKENDS, 17 OCT-22 NOV 2026	Evaluation period, both kinds	High school softball and travel ball. Chapter 3 lists the six weekends.
23 NOV 2026-2 JAN 2027	Quiet period	The calendar allows in-person contact on the college's campus only.
3 JAN-31 MAY 2027	Evaluation period	High school softball only.
1-11 JUN 2027	Dead period	Nothing.
12 JUN-31 JUL 2027	Contact period	High school softball and travel ball.

Proof: 2026-27 NCAA Recruiting Calendar, Division I Softball, updated 30 July 2026. Read 11 November 2026. Dead periods and shutdowns inside these blocks are in Chapter 3. The June dates carry the calendar's asterisk.

Read the table once more. Outside the two contact periods, the calendar marks travel ball for watching on six fall weekends only. The rest of the school year is high school softball only. And in an evaluation period a coach may watch but may not meet her off campus. So in 2026-27 a face-to-face meeting away from campus can happen only in the two contact periods. This is this book's reading of the printed calendar. The NCAA does not print it as one line.

These days bind Division I coaches only. Division II, Division III, NAIA and junior college coaches do not follow this calendar. Chapter 4 gives their rules.

THE EXTRA EVALUATION PERIOD

The calendar adds one more time when Division I coaches may watch. It reads: "During high school regional and state championship competition that does not occur during a dead period." The calendar prints no dates for it. Those dates come from your state association.

CAMPS

- **No recruiting talk before the date.** Before 1 p.m. Central on 1 September of junior year, a Division I softball coach may not hold a recruiting conversation at camp. The rule covers college camps and clinics, even one for younger girls. Bylaw 13.12.1.5.4.
- **What a camp is before that date.** It is teaching, and a chance to be watched. It is not a meeting about her future. A coach who stays quiet about recruiting is following the rule.
- **Where college staff may work.** Division I softball staff may work a private camp only on days when they may watch travel ball. The private camp must also be open to any player and advertised at least 14 days ahead. At other times they may work only college camps, on a college campus or at the college's own field. Bylaws 13.12.1.2.4 and 13.12.2.2.8. The calendar cites the same rule as 13.12.2.3.6, so the two papers number it differently.
- **Who else is at camp.** College players may be paid to work camps and clinics. The rule sets no limit on how many. Bylaw 17.23.7.

Proof: Division I Manual 2026-27 and the 2026-27 softball calendar. Read 11 November 2026. Camp prices are in Chapter 8.

CLUB AND TRAVEL BALL

More than one body runs travel softball. The sport's national governing body covers adults and youth, slow pitch and fast pitch. Its own pages print two sets of numbers. They do not agree, and neither one carries a date.

WHERE IT IS PRINTED	TEAMS	PEOPLE
The governing body's own website	"over 120,000 teams"	"more than one million" members: players, coaches and umpires
The governing body's page on a business networking site, as saved on 3 September 2026	"over 245,000 softball teams," with "over 83,000 youth girls' fast pitch softball teams"	"over 2.02 million players," with "over 1.2 million girls"

Both read 11 November 2026. Both sets are printed here because this book cannot tell which is current.

Travel teams also join membership bodies. One of them places teams in "one of our nine (9) Member Leagues" by where they are, for age groups from 8 and under (8U) to 18 and under (18U). That text is from its 2024-2025 season page. From the 2027 season, its membership no longer includes membership in the national governing body. Ask the club which bodies it has joined, and which events each one opens. SERVICE

How much travel ball does she need? One recruiting company prints an answer. It says four to five years of "high-level travel ball" for Division I. It says three to four years for Division II. It says two to three years for Division III and NAIA. No association prints such a rule. Treat it as one company's view. SERVICE

HOW THE OTHER LEVELS WATCH

- **Division II.** At a game or a practice, a coach waits until she is done for the day and has been released by the proper authority. Division II coaches' recruiting guide, updated 30 July 2026.
- **Division III.** No limit on how often or when a coach may watch. Bylaw 13.1.4.
- **NAIA.** A coach may watch her high school games and practices. It stays watching as long as the coach does not ask her to show a skill or run the workout. NAIA Official Handbook 2026-2027, Article II, Section C.
- **Junior college.** Staff may visit her at any place to recruit. NJCAA Bylaws, Article VI, Section 4.C.

HOW TO BUILD HER LIST

This book has no counted sample of softball rosters. It will not guess at one. Here is how a family builds its own. Start with schools that have what she wants to study. Open each team's roster page. Count the players at her position by class year. Mark the ones who will be gone before fall 2029. Do it for schools at all five levels. Chapter 2 gives the team counts by level. Division III alone has more teams than Division I. The junior college count is the weak one. The only number in hand is one company's 364. It covers all junior colleges, not only the NJCAA, and this book could read no split by NJCAA division. Treat 364 as unsettled.

6. WHAT TO SEND, AND WHAT GOOD VIDEO LOOKS LIKE

One email, from her, with two links. It is short. Every number in it says how it was measured, and when. Then one video that lets a coach check those numbers.

SUBJECT LINE, 73 CHARACTERS, NOT COUNTING SPACES

2029 shortstop, Anytown South HS · 2.9 home to first · 60 mph throw · 3.75 GPA · film inside

BODY, ABOUT 185 WORDS, FROM HER OWN MAILBOX

Coach Mardian,

My name is Casey Lindqvist. I play shortstop at Anytown South HS and I graduate in 2029. My travel team is the Anytown Storm, for players 16 and under. Our fall schedule is in the second link below.

School season, 24 games: .300 average, 1 home run, 10 RBIs, 5 steals, .980 fielding.

Measures, 14 August 2027, taken by my travel coach. Home to first in 2.9 seconds by stopwatch. Overhand throw 60 mph on a radar gun from behind, best three of six. Exit speed off a tee 68 mph, best three of five.

Unweighted GPA 3.75 on a 4.0 scale. I am on track for my 16 core courses. I want to study nursing.

I am a junior now, so I know you may write back. I watched two of your games on the stream last spring. How many middle infielders do you plan to add for 2029? And what time zone are you in, so I can call at a good hour?

Video, no login: example.com/casey-video
Schedule: example.com/casey-schedule

Thank you for reading this.

Casey Lindqvist
player@example.com · (555) 555-0148

The player, the school, the club and the coach are invented. This book's rule is that a sample email names no real high school, club, camp or service. The numbers only show the form, and the two links are placeholders.

WHY IT IS WRITTEN THIS WAY

- **She writes it, from her own mailbox.** The rules below are about what a coach may send to her. So the thread should be hers.
- **Class year, position and school sit in the subject.** A coach can sort it without opening it.
- **Every number has a tool and a date.** Say which tool was used. Say who held it. A coach cannot weigh a number that has no method.
- **Two questions a coach can answer in one line.** The first is the roster question from Chapter 2. The second is the time zone, so her first call lands at a good hour.
- **It names no place.** She asks for the coach's time zone. She does not guess at it.

WHEN A COACH MAY ANSWER

Nothing in the rule text this book read stops her from sending an email. The limit is on the coach. A Division I softball school may not send her "electronic correspondence" before 1 p.m. Central on 1 September of junior year. So an email to a Division I softball coach in 10th grade gets no recruiting answer. The coach may send a short reply that explains the

rule or points her to admissions. The reply may say nothing about the athletics program. Camp information may be sent at any time. That is the rule working. It is not a verdict on her. Bylaws 13.4.1.4, 13.4.1.13 and 13.4.1.14(b).

A phone call is tighter still. Before that date the staff may not even take her call. One recruiting company prints the line "can - and should - proactively contact college coaches at any time" for players. For a Division I softball phone call, the rule says no. Bylaw 13.1.3.2.8.

Division II, Division III, NAIA and junior college coaches may answer her at any time. So in 10th grade, send this email to those levels first. Send the Division I round in the week of 1 September 2027.

Proof: Division I Manual 2026-27. Division II Manual, Bylaw 13.1.3.1. Division III Manual, Bylaw 13.02.10. Read 11 November 2026. Chapter 11 explains one open point about texts and direct messages.

WHAT GOOD VIDEO LOOKS LIKE

No association prints a rule for recruiting video. This book found no softball coach on the record about how long a video should be. So it prints no number of minutes. What its sources do carry is how the common tests are run. A good video lets a coach see each test done the same way.

TEST	HOW ONE RECRUITING COMPANY SAYS IT IS RUN
PITCH SPEED	Fastball and changeup, three throws each, on a radar gun.
POP TIME	For catchers. A stopwatch runs from her first move to the ball reaching second base. Best three of six.
OVERHAND THROW	Shuffle and throw 60 feet. The radar gun reads from behind. Best three of six.
EXIT SPEED	Ball speed off the bat, hit from a tee. Best three of five.
HOME TO FIRST	A sprint of 60 feet, which the company also calls the 20-yard sprint.
OTHERS	A pro agility shuttle and a vertical jump.

The company says a national coaches' group built these tests. This book did not open that group's own test sheet. Read 11 November 2026. SERVICE

So film the tests she lists in her email. Show the radar gun or the stopwatch in the shot. Put the date, her name, her class year and her position on the first frame. Keep the link open, with no login. These four lines are this book's own advice. They are not a rule, and no coach this book read said them.

ONE COMPANY'S TARGET CHART

No college and no association publishes a pitch speed, a pop time or a sprint time that a player must reach. The chart below is one recruiting company's targets. The company does not say how many players it measured, in which years, or how. Use it to see the shape, not to judge your daughter. SERVICE

MEASURE	DIVISION I	DIVISION II	DIVISION III AND NAIA	JUNIOR COLLEGE
PITCHER, SPEED	63+ mph	58+ mph	55+ mph	54+ mph
CATCHER, POP TIME	1.8 seconds	1.9	2.1	2.1
CATCHER, THROW	63+ mph	58-60 mph	55+ mph	50-55 mph
MIDDLE INFIELD, HOME TO FIRST	2.8 or lower	2.9 or lower	3.0 or lower	3.2 or lower
MIDDLE INFIELD, THROW	62+ mph	60+ mph	58+ mph	55+ mph
CENTER FIELD, HOME TO FIRST	2.8 or lower	2.9 or lower	3.1 or lower	3.2 or lower

Read 11 November 2026. Other companies print other numbers. Chapter 8 shows how far apart they are on pitch speed.

7. WHAT THE PAPERWORK REALLY MEANS

There are three papers to know. The first is her account with the NCAA Eligibility Center. The second is the offer she signs. The third is the junior college letter, which works in a different way.

THE ELIGIBILITY CENTER ACCOUNT

- **When.** The NCAA guide says to register "before ninth grade." She is in 10th grade, so do it now.
- **Which account.** A Profile Page is for a student who is not being recruited yet, is not sure of her level, or is headed to Division III. It moves up to a certification account once a Division I or II school recruits her.
- **Why it matters.** She needs the paid certification account, or a fee waiver, to take a Division I official visit. She needs it to sign for a scholarship. She needs it to play at a Division I or II school.
- **What it costs.** On 11 November 2026 the live sign-up page showed two prices, $120 and $180. They were read as the price for US students and the price for students from other countries. "All fees are nonrefundable after 30 days." A fee waiver exists for students who qualify.

Proof: NCAA 2026-27 Guide for the College-Bound Student-Athlete, pages 6 and 7, and the NCAA certification sign-up page. Read 11 November 2026.

THE 16 CORE COURSES

LEVEL	WHAT SHE NEEDS	WHERE
DIVISION I	16 core courses, earned in four school years in a row from the start of ninth grade. Ten of the 16 must be done before her seventh semester starts. Seven of those ten must be in English, math and science. A core-course grade average of at least 2.3.	Guide, page 14
DIVISION II	16 core courses and a core-course grade average of at least 2.2.	Guide, page 16
DIVISION III	A Profile Page account. The guide also has a Division III amateurism part, which this book did not read in full.	Guide, page 6

A core course is a class the NCAA has approved. The guide warns that not every high school class counts toward the 16. So ask her counselor which of her classes are NCAA-approved core courses. The guide's wording is on page 9.

THE PAPER SHE SIGNS IN DIVISION I OR II

- **The old letter is gone.** Division I ended the National Letter of Intent on 9 October 2024. Division II did the same at its meeting of 21 to 22 October 2024.
- **What took its place.** A written offer of athletics aid. Softball sits in the group "All Other Division I and II Sports." It has no early period and no late period of its own.
- **The date.** The rule is the second Wednesday in November, at 7 a.m. in Division I. For 2026-27 the NCAA printed 11 November 2026. The last day to sign is set by each school's own policy.
- **Her date.** She signs in the fall of 2028. The NCAA has printed no date for that year. Chapter 3 works it out as Wednesday 8 November 2028 and tags it PROJECTED.
- **The quiet week.** In 2026 a Division I softball dead period ran from 9 to 12 November. Division II had one from 7 a.m. on 9 November to 7 a.m. on 11 November.
- **What signing does.** Once she signs, other schools that give athletics aid must stop recruiting her.
- **How big the aid is.** At a settlement school, aid may be any amount, full or partial. No school must give a full scholarship. Ask how much, for what costs, and for how many years.
- **The second paper.** A school may also give her a written offer about payments for her name, image and likeness, or a share of school revenue. It may come on or after 1 August of senior year. She may not sign it before the signing date.
- **One note on the roster count.** The commission's page names a group called Designated Student-Athletes. They were named in summer 2025, when the settlement rules began. They do not count against the 25-player limit. This book's sources do not say what the title is for. Ask the coach if any current players hold it.

Proof: NCAA news releases of 9 October 2024 and 23 October 2024. NCAA signing dates sheet for 2026-27. Division I Manual, Bylaw 13.02.13.1(f) and Figure 13-2. Division II Manual, Bylaw 13.02.10.1(c). NCAA settlement question-and-answer, updated 29 May 2026, items B3 and B11. The two 2026-27 recruiting calendars. College Sports Commission roster limits page. Read 11 November 2026. The signing dates do not apply to players who transfer from another four-year school.

THE JUNIOR COLLEGE LETTER

- The NJCAA still uses a Letter of Intent. The softball signing date on its chart is "Nov 1."
- She "must have completed their junior year of high school to sign."
- The letter lasts one school year, from 1 August to 31 July.
- The college must tell her by 15 June if it will sign her again for the next year.
- If she is not re-signed by 15 June, she "automatically becomes recruitable." She can sign with a different NJCAA college on 16 June.
- If she signs with a second NJCAA college before the first one lets her go, she cannot play for one school year.
- A region or a conference may set tighter rules than the national ones.

Proof: NJCAA Sports Procedures Chart for 2026-27. NJCAA Bylaws 2026-27, Article VI, Sections 2.A.5 and 3.A. Read 11 November 2026.

THE NAIA: GRADES CAN MAKE ROOM FOR HER

The NAIA handbook for 2026-2027 has no bylaw on a letter of intent. What it does hold is a money rule worth knowing. A team has 10 full grants to share. One player may get no more than the real cost of tuition, required fees, books and supplies, and her own room and board. But aid to a new freshman with strong grades counts less against the team's 10, or not at all.

HOW MUCH IS LEFT OUT	HIGH SCHOOL GRADES	TEST SCORE, FIRST LINE	TEST SCORE, SECOND LINE	CLASS RANK
HALF	3.50 to 3.74	1140 SAT or 23 ACT, for tests on or after 1 May 2019	1130 SAT or 23 ACT, no dates given	Top 11% to 25%
ALL	3.75 to 4.0	1280 SAT or 27 ACT	1270 SAT or 27 ACT	Top 10%

Proof: NAIA Official Handbook 2026-2027, financial aid policy, items G and H, and Bylaws Article II, Section B, Item 1a. Read 11 November 2026. The same policy page prints both test-score lines. This book prints both because it cannot tell which one a school will use.

- Her aid counts against the team's 10 only if she plays in more than 20% of the varsity games, or in the postseason. For softball the handbook puts that at 11 games.
- Federal and state grants, federal or state work study and campus jobs do not count against the 10. Athletic grants, academic scholarships and school-funded work study do.
- Pay for real work does not count as a benefit. The handbook sets no cap on hours or pay rate that this book could find.

Proof: the same financial aid policy, items B, C, D and F, and Bylaws Article II, Section B, Item 3. Read 11 November 2026.

IF A PROFESSIONAL TEAM CALLS

The rules differ by level. Division I lets a girl who is not yet in college try out with a professional team, as long as she gets no more than her real and needed costs. The NAIA is stricter on paper: signing with any professional team ends her amateur standing in that sport. For high school play, the national handbook leaves the amateur rule to its members. So the rule that covers her school team is the one written by your state association.

Proof: Division I Manual, Bylaw 12.2.1.1. NAIA Official Handbook 2026-2027, Bylaws Article VII, Section D. NFHS Handbook 2024-25, pages 23 to 25, the newest edition this book could open. Read 11 November 2026.

8. WHAT IT COSTS, AND WHAT IS WASTED

Every price here was read on the seller's own page on 11 November 2026. None is made up, and none is an average. They are examples, not a survey. Where no page gave a number, this chapter says so.

CAMP PRICES, PER PLAYER

WHAT	PRICE	PAGE IT CAME FROM
One college's prospect camp, one day, 14 November 2026, grades 7 to 12	$100. The same page lists a youth camp at $50.	The college's camp sign-up page
A second college's fall prospect camp, 15 November 2026	$150	That college's camp sign-up page
A third college's prospect camp, 19 September 2026, classes of 2027 to 2029	"$150 per player"	The college's athletics news page
A camp with coaches from many colleges, 26 July 2026, about four hours	"$325," plus a processing fee	The camp's own page

SERVICE All four read 11 November 2026. The range on these four pages is $100 to $325 for one day. That range is this book's own summary. Chapter 11 gives each web address.

TOURNAMENT AND SHOWCASE FEES, PER TEAM

These fees are charged to the team. The club splits them among its families.

EVENT	TEAM FEE	NOTE ON THE PAGE
A showcase tournament for players 14 and under (14U) up to 18 and under (18U)	$625	None.
A fall showcase, 23 to 25 October 2026, four games promised	"$1,195.00 entry fee"	Teams must be signed up with one travel-ball membership body.
One organizer's 2026-27 events	$1,250 and $1,675	"All inclusive," with no gate fees.
A team camp tournament, 11 to 12 July 2026, five games promised	$1295	The same organizer also charges team gate fees: "$450 for three day events and $300 for two day events."
A showcase, 14 to 16 November 2026, five games promised	"$1,795.00 entry fee"	None.
A national championship, 2026	"$2,900.00"	Due by 1 March 2026 for returning and invited teams.

SERVICE All six read 11 November 2026. The range on these six pages is $625 to $2,900 per team per event. That is before gate fees, travel and lodging. The range is this book's own summary.

CLUB MEMBERSHIP FEES, AND CLUB DUES

One travel-ball membership body charges a team fee each year. For one of its membership levels the fee is $100 for a team of players 12 and under (12U) and $200 for a 14U, 16U or 18U team. The page says: "This is an annual fee good through August 16, 2027." This is a fee for the team, not for each girl. SERVICE

Now the number families ask for most: what a travel team costs for a season. This book found no figure it could cite. Clubs set their own dues. No association prints a national number. So ask the club for one page that shows the dues, what they cover, and what each event adds.

The membership fee was read on 11 November 2026 from the body's help page, through a search excerpt. The fee text sits in a folded part of that page.

WHAT FAMILIES SPEND, ALL SPORTS TOGETHER

SOURCE	WHAT IT SAYS
PARENT SURVEY, 2024	"The average U.S. sports family spent $1,016 on their child's primary sport in 2024, a 46% increase since 2019." Add $475 for the same child's other sports. The total is "nearly $1,500 annually for one child." Answers ran from nothing to almost $25,000.
SAME GROUP, 2019	"Families spend $693 per child for one sport each year." The largest parts were travel at $196, equipment at $144, lessons at $134, registration at $125 and camps at $81.

Proof: Aspen Institute Project Play parent survey, news page from February 2025, and the State of Play 2019 report. Read 11 November 2026. These are all sports pooled. This book found no softball-only figure. The 46 is the survey's own figure. Dividing the two averages printed here gives a rise of 46.6 percent.

TWO MORE NUMBERS TO KEEP IN VIEW

- **The Eligibility Center fee.** $120 on the live page, as Chapter 7 explains.
- **What a scholarship is worth.** One recruiting company prints an average for softball. It says about $20,715 a year in Division I. It says about $7,281 a year in Division II. It took both numbers from a second site. It shows no year and no method. SERVICE
- **Why most awards are partial.** Division II has 7.2 scholarships to spread over a squad that averages 23.1 players. Split evenly, that is less than a third of a scholarship each. That last line is this book's arithmetic.

WHAT IS WASTED

- **A camp bought as a meeting.** Before 1 p.m. Central on 1 September of junior year, a Division I softball coach may not hold a recruiting conversation at camp. A camp at $100 to $325 buys teaching and a look. It does not buy a conversation. Bylaw 13.12.1.5.4.
- **A showcase on the wrong weekend.** In 2026-27 Division I coaches may watch travel ball in the two contact periods and on six fall weekends. Before the team pays an entry fee, check the date against Chapter 3. Then ask the event which college coaches came last year.
- **A trip planned on last year's June dates.** The June dead period and the summer contact period move with the Women's College World Series.
- **A number bought as a goal.** See the table below.

FOUR COMPANIES, FOUR ANSWERS ON PITCH SPEED

WHO PRINTS IT	DIVISION I PITCHER	DIVISION III AND NAIA	JUNIOR COLLEGE
Company A, no date read	63+ mph	55+ mph	54+ mph
Company B, page dated 19 April 2026	64-70 mph for "D1 Power 4," 60-64 mph for "D1 Mid-Major"	53-58 mph	Not given
Company C, page dated 3 July 2026	Four tiers, from 60 mph to 72+ mph	53 / 56 / 60+ mph	55 / 58 / 62+ mph
Company D, no date on the page	"60+, 63+ top"	Not read for this book	Not read for this book

SERVICE All four read 11 November 2026. Company C gives three numbers per level: on the radar, competitive and elite. Chapter 11 names the four pages.

RECRUITING SERVICES, NOT SCOUTS

Look at the last column. Company A puts junior college pitchers below its Division III line. Company C puts them above. Company D also asks a Division I pitcher for an earned run average of 1.0 or less. Company A says below 2.50. None of the four says how many pitchers it measured. These are recruiting services, not scouts. No college and no association prints a pitch speed she must reach. Do not pay for a target. Measure her the same way each time, and send the number with its date.

9. CHECKLIST BY GRADE

One row per stretch of time, in order. Cross items off. Dates in 2027 and 2028 are PROJECTED, as Chapter 3 explains, so check them again when the new calendars are printed.

WHEN	DO THIS
9TH GRADE DONE	Keep every grade. The 16 core courses count from the start of ninth grade. The NCAA guide says to register with the Eligibility Center before ninth grade. If that did not happen, do it this month.
10TH GRADE THIS YEAR	Open the Eligibility Center account. Ask the counselor which of her classes are NCAA-approved core courses. Build her list at all five levels, the way Chapter 5 shows. Write to Division II, Division III, NAIA and junior college coaches, who may answer now. Do not read Division I silence as a no. Get her measured, with the tool and the date written down. Check event dates against the six fall weekends and the summer contact period before the team pays.
SUMMER 2027	From 1 June a junior college may pay for a visit. From 15 June a Division II coach may meet her in person, and a Division II school may pay for a visit. Play in the summer contact period. A Division I coach's trips to watch her from 1 June through 31 August do not count against that school's seven.
11TH GRADE FALL 2027	At 1 p.m. Central on 1 September 2027, Division I softball opens. Send the Chapter 6 email that week. Take calls. Do not book a visit inside a dead period. Before a paid Division I visit, send a transcript, have the certification account paid for, and be on the school's request list.
11TH GRADE WINTER AND SPRING	From 1 January 2028 a Division III school may pay for a visit. Count her core courses with the counselor: ten of the 16 must be done before 12th grade starts, seven of them in English, math and science. Division I coaches may watch her school team this spring. They may also watch regional and state championship play, on dates set by your state association.
SUMMER 2028	The June dead period and the summer contact period move with the Women's College World Series. Read the printed dates before booking travel. From 1 August 2028 a school may hand her a written offer about payments. She may not sign it yet.
12TH GRADE FALL 2028	Ask each school for its number in writing in September. The junior college signing date is 1 November. The first day to sign a written offer of athletics aid in Division I or II is the second Wednesday in November. That works out as 8 November 2028. Expect a dead period that week.
AFTER SHE SIGNS	Finish all 16 core courses and graduate. Keep the core-course grade average at 2.3 or higher for Division I, or 2.2 or higher for Division II. If she signed a junior college letter, mark 15 June of her first college year. That is the day the college must say if it will sign her again.

Proof for each line is in the chapter that covers it: Chapter 3 for dates, Chapter 4 for contact and visits, Chapter 7 for the paper. All read 11 November 2026.

THREE DATES FOR THE FRIDGE DOOR

First, 1 September 2027 at 1 p.m. Central, when Division I softball may first call and write. Second, June 2028, when the dead period ends on the day the college season ends. Third, 8 November 2028, the first day to sign. All three are worked out from the rules. None is printed yet for her years.

10. TEN WAYS FAMILIES GET SOFTBALL WRONG

1. **They trust "June 15."** That is the general Division I date for email and mail. Softball's date is 1 p.m. Central on 1 September of junior year. For the class of 2029 that is 1 September 2027.
2. **They call a Division I coach in 9th or 10th grade.** The staff may not take the call. The family hears nothing and decides the school is not interested. The silence was the rule.
3. **They book a visit for the first week of September.** On the printed 2026-27 calendar, 28 August to 3 September is a dead period. The phone opens on 1 September. The door does not.
4. **They plan June from last year's dates.** The June dead period and the summer contact period are set from the Women's College World Series. They move every year.
5. **They count 25 scholarships.** The 25 is a roster limit at settlement schools. It is a cap on people. Other Division I schools still work under the old 12 scholarships, and no public list shows which is which.
6. **They pay for a camp to talk to the coach.** Before 1 p.m. Central on 1 September of junior year, a Division I softball coach may not hold a recruiting conversation at camp.
7. **They pay for a showcase without checking the date.** In 2026-27, Division I coaches may watch travel ball in two contact periods and on six fall weekends.
8. **They chase a pitch speed from a chart.** Four companies print four different Division I numbers. None is a rule, and none says how it was measured.
9. **They skip Division III, the NAIA and junior college.** The NCAA counts more softball teams in Division III than in Division I. And the 6.5 percent odds count NCAA players only.
10. **They plan on a professional career.** The next section says what this book could and could not confirm.

Proof for each line is in Chapters 2 to 8. All read 11 November 2026.

AFTER COLLEGE: WHAT IS KNOWN, AND WHAT IS NOT

A professional softball league began play in the United States in June 2025. It has six teams and a 25-game season. In May 2026 it held a college draft, and 17 players were picked. Set that beside 21,916 NCAA softball players, 6,956 of them in Division I.

This book could not confirm what that league pays its players. It could not confirm any other professional softball league in the United States in 2026. It could not confirm softball at the 2028 Olympic Games. The NCAA's own table of professional odds has no softball row. So this book makes no promise about a professional road. Plan on the degree.

One rule matters while she is in college. A Division I athlete "shall not request to be placed on the draft list or supplemental draft list of a professional league." That is Bylaw 12.2.3.2.

One piece of money is certain. The NCAA Postgraduate Scholarship is "a one-time $7,000 scholarship" for graduate study. Up to 100 are given each year, split evenly between men and women across the fall, winter and spring seasons.

Proof: the league's own pages and two league news pages dated 4 May 2026 and 18 July 2026. NCAA Research probability table, last updated March 2026. NCAA Postgraduate Scholarship page. Read 11 November 2026.

THE JUNIOR COLLEGE ROAD

NJCAA LEVEL	WHAT A SOFTBALL SCHOLARSHIP MAY COVER
DIVISION I	Tuition and fees, room and board, books, up to $250 in supplies, and one round trip home a year.
DIVISION II	Tuition and fees, books, and up to $250 in supplies.
DIVISION III	No athletic scholarship of any kind.

- **24 is a count of signed players.** It is not 24 full scholarships. A signed player counts as one of the 24 "regardless of the amount of athletic scholarship."
- **The letter lasts one school year.** If she is not re-signed by 15 June, she may sign with a different NJCAA college on 16 June.
- **A move in the middle of the year has a catch.** The Division I rule names softball. A player who first enrolls at the Division I school after its first term may not play until the next school year. The same rule is written for transfers from four-year schools.
- **Other levels may recruit her freely.** Since 7 April 2025 an NAIA coach may start contact with a junior college student at any time. Division II puts no limits on mail, calls or meetings with two-year college transfers.
- **Not every two-year college is in the NJCAA.** Some play under other rule books. This book did not open them.

Proof: NJCAA Bylaws 2026-27, Article VI, Sections 2 and 3. NJCAA Sports Procedures Chart for 2026-27. Division I Manual, Bylaws 14.5.4.1.1, 14.5.4.2.4 and 14.5.5.4. NAIA Official Handbook 2026-2027, note to Article II, Section D, Item 1b. Division II coaches' recruiting guide, updated 30 July 2026. Read 11 November 2026.

THE FIVE-YEAR CLOCK

Division I Bylaw 12.1 says a player's time to play "shall be limited to five years." It was revised on 24 June 2026 and took effect on 1 August 2026. This book did not read how junior college seasons count against the five years. So do not assume a junior college year is free. Before she enrolls, ask the Division I school's compliance office in writing how many seasons she would have left.

11. SOURCES, AND WHAT WE COULD NOT SETTLE

Every rule, number and date in this book came from one of the documents below. Each was read on 11 November 2026. Where two official pages disagree, both figures are printed in the chapter that uses them.

NCAA Division I Manual 2026-27, PDF made 11 November 2026, for every Division I bylaw in this book. The softball contact lines carry the note "Adopted: 6/24/26." web3.ncaa.org/lsdbi/reports/getReport/90008

NCAA Division II Manual 2026-27, PDF made 11 November 2026, for contact, visits, the 7.2 equivalency and the signing date rule. web3.ncaa.org/lsdbi/reports/getReport/90010

NCAA Division III Manual 2026-27, PDF made 11 November 2026, for contact, visits and the rule against athletics aid. web3.ncaa.org/lsdbi/reports/getReport/90011

2026-27 NCAA Recruiting Calendar, Division I Softball, "Updated: July 30, 2026," for every HARD row in Chapter 3, the five period meanings and the asterisk. ncaaorg.s3.amazonaws.com/compliance/recruiting/calendar/2026-27/2026-27D1Rec_WSBRecruitingCalendar.pdf

2026-27 NCAA Recruiting Calendar, Division II Sports, "Updated: July 30, 2026," for the dead period of 9 to 11 November 2026. ncaaorg.s3.amazonaws.com/compliance/recruiting/calendar/2026-27/2026-27D2Rec_RecruitingCalendar_AllSports.pdf

Division II Coaches Off-Campus Recruiting Guide 2026-27, "Updated: July 30, 2026." ncaaorg.s3.amazonaws.com/compliance/recruiting/calendar/2026-27/2026-27D2REC_RecGuide.pdf

NCAA recruiting calendars page, which on 11 November 2026 linked only 2026-27 files. ncaa.org/eligibility-center/recruiting

NCAA Question and Answer: Implementation of the House Settlement, "Updated May 29, 2026," items B2, B3 and B11. ncaaorg.s3.amazonaws.com/governance/d1/legislation/May2026D1Gov_PhaseEightSetQuestionandAnswer.pdf

College Sports Commission, roster limits page, for the softball line "old scholarship limit 12, new roster limit 25" and how a roster is turned in. collegesportscommission.org/roster-limits

NCAA news release of 9 October 2024, ending the National Letter of Intent in Division I. ncaa.org/news/media-center-di-council-approves-changes-to-notification-of-transfer-windows-in-basketball-football

NCAA news release of 23 October 2024 and the Division II summary of actions, for the same step in Division II. ncaa.org/news/media-center-dii-management-council-supports-automatic-qualification-proposal-for-football and ncaaorg.s3.amazonaws.com/committees/d2/mc_mgmt/Oct2024D2MCEB_SummaryActions.pdf

NCAA signing dates for 2026-27, for 11 November 2026. athleticsaid.s3.amazonaws.com/2026-27DI_SigningDates.pdf

NCAA 2026-27 Guide for the College-Bound Student-Athlete, pages 6, 7, 9, 14 and 16. s3.amazonaws.com/fs.ncaa.org/Docs/eligibility_center/Student_Resources/CBSA.pdf

NCAA Eligibility Center certification sign-up page, for $120 and $180. web3.ncaa.org/ecwr3/register/CERTIFICATION

NAIA Official Handbook 2026-2027, for aid limits, tryouts, visits and amateur rules. naia.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/07/2026_Official_Handbook.pdf

NAIA web pages on recruiting and for high school students, for "no recruiting calendar" and the second tryout wording. naia.org/why-naia/recruiting and naia.org/student-athletes/prospective/high-school-students

NJCAA Handbook Bylaws 2026-27, file dated 9 September 2026, for visits, the letter of intent and what aid may cover. A newer file, dated 5 November 2026, is posted and was not read for this book. njcaa.org/compliance

NJCAA Sports Procedures Chart for 2026-27, for 24 signees and the 1 November signing date. The chart says it is tentative. The chart is reissued during the year, so check the association's own page for the newest file. njcaa.org/compliance

NFHS Handbook 2024-25, pages 23 to 25. assets.nfhs.org/umbraco/media/7213201/2024-25-nfhs-handbook_final.pdf

NCAA membership and sport sponsorship page, for 308, 274 and 396 teams. ncaa.org/about-us/membership-directory/membership-composition-and-sport-sponsorship

NCAA Sports Sponsorship and Participation Rates Report, PDF pages 92 and 94, for teams, players and squad sizes. ncaaorg.s3.amazonaws.com/research/sportpart/2025RES_SportsSponsorshipParticipationRatesReport.pdf

NCAA Research, probability of competing beyond high school, "Last Updated: March 2026," for 338,315, 21,916 and 6.5 percent. ncaaorg.s3.amazonaws.com/research/pro_beyond/RES_ProbabilityBeyondHSFiguresMethod.pdf

NAIA statistics site, "2026 NAIA Softball Standings," counted by hand at 194 rows. naiastats.prestosports.com/sports/sball/2025-26/standings

USA Softball, the national governing body, for its two sets of size numbers. usasoftball.com/about and its company page at linkedin.com/company/usasoftball

Alliance Fastpitch, the travel-ball membership body quoted in Chapters 5 and 8, for the nine leagues and the $100 and $200 "Super Division" team fees. afp.isportz.co and thealliancefastpitch.com/help-faqs

Camp prices in Chapter 8, in table order. These pages are used here as examples of a price, not a shortlist of camps. longwoodsoftball.totalcamps.com/shop/EVENT, gannonsoftballcamps.totalcamps.com/shop, govaliants.com/news/2026/8/24/registration-now-available-for-2026-softball-prospect-camp.aspx and pgfsoftballcamps.com

Tournament fees in Chapter 8, in table order. They are examples too. parsonssportsranch.com/college-softball-showcase, softball.exposureevents.com/263162/bluegrass-invitational-showcase, team1fastpitch.com/about/2024-2025-tournament-list/44273, carolinaspremierfastpitch.com/page/show/6801725-2025-tournaments, softball.exposureevents.com/265046/the-nit and pgfnationals.com

Aspen Institute Project Play, the 2024 parent survey and the State of Play 2019 report. projectplay.org/news/2025/2/24/project-play-survey-family-spending-on-youth-sports-rises-46-over-five-years and aspeninstitute.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/05/2019_SOP_National_Final.pdf

Company A in Chapters 6 and 8, and the source of the travel-ball years, the 7.8 percent odds, the 197 and 364 school counts and the scholarship values: NCSA. ncsasports.org/softball/recruiting-guidelines and ncsasports.org/softball/scholarships

Company B in Chapter 8, for its pitch speeds by level. Page dated 19 April 2026. nextcommit.ai/blog/how-to-get-recruited-for-college-softball

Company C in Chapter 8, for its pitch speeds by level. Page dated 3 July 2026. commitbound.com/softball/guides/softball-pitcher-recruiting

Company D in Chapter 8, for its pitch speed and earned run average lines. The page shows no date. dynamitesports.com/softball-recruiting-standards

The site quoted in Chapter 4 for "June 15": everysoftballgirl.com/guides/college-softball-recruiting-guide

The professional league in Chapter 10 is the Athletes Unlimited Softball League. theausl.com/about and two league news pages on mlb.com dated 4 May 2026 and 18 July 2026.

NCAA future championship dates page, for the 2028 Women's College World Series: it starts 1 June 2028, and the final series is 7, 8 and, if needed, 9 June. ncaa.com/championships/softball/d1/future-info

NCAA Postgraduate Scholarship page. ncaa.org/what-we-do/scholarships-grants/postgraduate-scholarship-program

WHAT WE COULD NOT SETTLE

Three items below carry the mark UNCONFIRMED. It means a claim that this book has no document for yet.

- **Her own calendars.** The 2027-28 and 2028-29 Division I softball calendars are not published. Neither are the signing dates for those years. Every date for her junior and senior years is PROJECTED.
- **The 2028 signing week.** The date of 8 November 2028 is this book's arithmetic from the second-Wednesday rule. The dead period around it is not worked out, because no rule text for it was read.
- **Texts and direct messages in Division I.** UNCONFIRMED The manual says only "electronic correspondence" and names no list of channels. So this book does not print them as covered, or as free. Ask the school's compliance office how it reads the term. Division I Manual, Bylaw 13.4.1.
- **How many official visits she may take in all.** One Division I bylaw points to another for that limit. The second bylaw's number does not appear as a heading in the manual text read. No total cap was found.
- **Which Division I schools opted in.** No list was found of schools outside the five defendant conferences that chose the settlement rules. Ask each school.
- **Designated Student-Athletes.** The commission's page says players given that title in summer 2025 do not count against the 25-player limit. The text this book read does not say what the title is for.
- **NAIA tryouts.** The handbook says two days per school. Two NAIA web pages say two days in a whole career. Not settled.
- **NAIA test scores.** The policy prints two SAT lines, 1130 and 1270, and 1140 and 1280. Not settled.
- **NAIA letters of intent.** The handbook has no such bylaw. Whether one NAIA conference adds its own letter or its own recruiting rule was not checked.
- **The subject split of the 16 core courses.** It is a picture table in the guide and was not read again for this book.
- **Junior college team counts.** UNCONFIRMED The NJCAA's statistics site was turned off and its new team list did not load. The only number in hand is one company's 364.
- **The NAIA team count.** A hand count found 194, and 192 with games played. One company says 197. The dates differ, which may be why.
- **Two-year colleges outside the NJCAA.** Their rule books were not opened.
- **How big travel softball is.** The governing body prints two sets of numbers. No count was found for the travel-ball membership bodies.

- **Players recruited per team per year.** No association publishes it. Only the squad arithmetic in Chapter 2 exists.
- **A softball-only family cost, and travel team dues.** Not found. The spending figures in Chapter 8 are for all sports.
- **The camp colleges' levels.** The camp pages do not print the division, so Chapter 8 leaves it out.
- **Measures by position.** Company targets only. The companies disagree, and none prints how many players it measured. The coaches' group's own test sheet was not opened.
- **Which positions commit first.** No source with authority was found.
- **Pro pay, other pro leagues, and the Olympics.** UNCONFIRMED None could be checked.
- **How junior college seasons count against the five years.** Not read. Ask the school.
- **What former players do next.** No softball-only data was found on coaching, medicine or other careers.
- **A newer high school handbook.** The 2024-25 edition was the newest one that could be opened.

Made by The Commit Book. Education, not legal advice. No result, no playing time, no acceptance, and no money is promised. Rule text, calendars and price pages checked 11 November 2026. The player, school, club and coach in the sample email are invented.